

That Memory Card has a name!

There is a wide variety of memory cards and flash storage media in the market, and in common use. We have seen people calling these everything from “memory” to “GB”. Memory cards following the specifications of SanDisk, the specifications of the Secure Digital (SD) group with Panasonic, SanDisk, Toshiba and Kodak and propriety Sony specifications are commonly in the market. Although they might look similar and serve the same purpose, the Sony Micro, is not compatible with the microSD specification. SanDisk is the only company that manufactures memory cards of all these specifications, and is even involved with Sony. The SDHC (Secure Digital High Capacity) variants for the SD cards offer more storage capacity within the same form factors.



A CompactFlash card is typically used in prosumer, superzoom and dSLR cameras

The SD Flash card is commonly used in consumer digital cameras, some camcorders and PMPs



The Short Lived MiniSD specification, was used in PMPs, cameras and some mobile phones



The microSD card is the smallest flash memory available to the general public, and is used in phones, gaming consoles, increasingly in PMPs and small digital cameras



The Memory Stick Micro M2 is not to be confused with the MiniSD card, and is used in mobile phones and some PMPs



The Memory Stick Pro Duo is a newer standard by Sony, used in camcorders, cameras and for gaming consoles

Sony Memory Stick, used on older cameras and camcorders. If you have a device that uses this, it is time to get a replacement



Taking care of your flash memory

- Minimise the number of times you access the card. This means tracking every read and write operation, and carefully reading only the number of times necessary. Copy the files off the card before editing them or uploading them.
- Wipe the card clean, but don't do this excessively.
- Use the “safely remove” or “unmount” option before removing your card from a computer
- Don't “hot-swap”, which is removing or putting in a memory card when the device is turned on, even if your device supports this
- Keep a backup card handy at all times, so that your work does not stop in it's tracks.
- Brace for memory failure, your card is going to go kaput some time or another. Be prepared for it with regular backups.

What to do with an .iso file

You got your hands on one of those .iso files, and have no clue how to use it? An .iso file is an “image” of a CD or a DVD medium. This means that all the data that could have been burned on these media are stored, shared or distributed using a convenient package. Instead of a folder with the media contents, an .iso file is used. There are some benefits however, an .iso file can contain instructions for the processor to boot an operating system within the image file. There are many approaches to use a .iso file.

1 Burn a CD/DVD

If the size of the .iso is less than 700 MB, it can fit on a CD, otherwise you need a DVD. You need a drive that can burn the media for this.

Step 1: Put a blank CD / DVD in the DVD drive

Step 2: Install a disc burning application such as Nero or Burn4Free

Step 3: Open the .iso file using the application. If you drag/drop the .iso file into the window of the burning application, the .iso file will be burnt as is.

2 Extract the contents

You can directly access the contents of the .iso file on your computer. This action is similar to unpacking a .zip or .rar archive. Note that this approach will not work for operating systems and some games.

Step 1: Install an unpacking application that supports .iso files. 7zip or MagicISO will work fine. Step 2: Right click on the .iso file, and select “unpack here” or similar option

Step 3: Choose location for extracting the data, and use it directly from there

3 Mount the image file

There are applications available that confuse the computer into thinking that there is another DVD drive attached, when all the software is doing is reading the .iso file as if it were a CD or DVD drive. This approach also will not work for installing operating systems.

Step 1: Download and install MagicDisc, it is a small virtual drive software

Step 2: Start up MagicDisc, and go to File>Open

Step 3: Navigate to the .iso file, to mount the .iso on a virtual drive